Country Profile: Cyprus

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 2
- Plurality religion: Greek Orthodox
- Official language: Greek, Turkish
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Greek Cypriots

Historical Background

Cyprus gained independence from British colonial rule in 1960 with the signing of the Zurich-London agreement, which established a power-sharing arrangement between the Greek Cypriot majority and the Turkish Cypriot minority. Tensions between the two communities led to a 1974 coup by Greek Cypriot nationalists aiming to unify Greece with Cyprus but ultimately prompting a Turkish military intervention and subsequent Turkish control of the northern part of the island. The de facto division of the country resulted in the displacement of Greek Cypriots and the establishment of the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus. Efforts to reunify the island have been ongoing, but a comprehensive resolution remains elusive, contributing to ongoing tensions between Greece and Turkey. The North Turkish occupied territories have been listed as a territorial loss for Cyprus as of 1974.[1]

Groups

- **Greek Cypriots** represent the largest group in Cyprus, making up about 75% of the population.[2]
  The majority speak Greek and practice the Greek Orthodox religion. These identity markers are particularly significant in the context of interactions with the Turkish Cypriot minority in the northern part of Cyprus. The peaceful coexistence of Greek and Turkish Cypriots continued for more than four centuries until independence.[3]

[1] Mallinson, 2005.
[2] AMAR, 2016.
[3] Minority rights, 2015.

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The group has been politically dominant since the mid-1960s, making it a core group in the country.[4]

- **Turkish Cypriots** are primarily concentrated in the northern part of the island and make up approximately 18% of the country's population.[5] The majority speak Turkish and practice Sunni Islam.[6] These identity markers are significant, as the ethno-religious divisions in Cyprus have fueled the long-standing self-determination conflict with the Greek Cypriot majority.[7]

State Profile

Official Language

The 1960 Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus recognizes both Greek and Turkish as official languages. Legislative and executive acts are drafted in both languages, and administrative documents are provided in the recipient's language of choice. Both languages appear on coins, currency notes, and stamps, and the Turkish language faces no official or legal restrictions.[8] However, since the de facto partition of the island, Greek has enjoyed an unofficially privileged position over Turkish. The media predominantly uses Greek, with some programs in Turkish, and Turkish migrants may have their citizenship applications rejected due to insufficient knowledge of Greek.[9]

Official Religion

Cyprus has no official state religion, and the 1960 Constitution recognizes the right to "freedom of thought, conscience and religion."[10] Regardless, the country is predominantly Christian, specifically Greek Orthodox, reflecting the demographic majority of Greek Cypriots who follow this faith.

Education Policies

The contemporary educational system in Cyprus is compulsory from ages 5 to 15, beginning with primary education for six years, followed by three years of lower secondary education. Upper secondary education offers three paths: academic, technical, and

[4] EPR-ED, 2021.
[5] AMAR, 2016.
[6] Ethnologue, 2024; Joshua Project, 2024.
[7] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[8] Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus, 1960 Article 3
[9] Trimikliniotis, 2015, 23.
[10] Ibid, Article 18: 1.

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vocational, all of which prepare students for university entry.[11] Cyprus has a range of private primary and secondary schools across the island, most of which use English as the language of instruction.[12] Many of these schools follow the British curriculum, while others offer the International Baccalaureate program.

The segregation of the education system in Cyprus has evolved over time. Following Cypriot independence in 1960, educational responsibilities for the Greek and Turkish communities were assigned to the Greek Communal Assembly and Turkish Communal Assembly, but following inter-communal troubles, the Greek Communal Assembly was dissolved.[13] The physical separation between groups intensified up until the 1974 invasion by Turkey, resulting in the de facto division of the island. During the period 1964–1974, the Turkish enclaves were run by the Turkish Cypriot Provisional Administration (TCPA) and had their own judiciary and police force, along with a separate segregated school system.

The education system post-1974 can be considered as unified, guided by Article 20 of the Constitution, which grants everyone the right to receive an education.[14] There are no legal barriers preventing Greek Cypriots from attending Turkish-speaking schools or vice versa, which helps to promote a cross-community educational environment. In the southern part of the island, Turkish Cypriots often attend Greek public schools, as there are no Turkish public schools available.[15]

Language Education Policies

The Constitution does not address educational language policy in Cyprus, although it makes the provision that every person has the right to receive an education in their native language. However, after the de-facto division of the island, Turkish schools are no longer operational in the south of Cyprus. The language of instruction in public schools is Greek, and the inclusion of the Turkish language in school curricula has been significantly reduced since the partition.[16] At present, Turkish language instruction in public schools is treated in the same way as other foreign languages: that is, as an optional language class in secondary school.[17] English is taught as a second language in public schools

[11] Scolaro, 2024.
[12] UNHCR, 2024.
[13] CIA, 1970, 6.
[14] Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus, 1960. Article 20.
[15] L'Aménagement Linguistique dans le Monde, 2024.
[16] UNHCR, 2024.
[17] Ioannou, 2020, 135.

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from the first grade.[18] Private schools may teach in another language of instruction on the condition that modern Greek is given as a compulsory subject to all children with at least one Greek Cypriot parent.[19]

Religious Education Policies

Although Cyprus has no official state religion, Greek Orthodox teachings are a mandatory part of the curriculum in public schools at both primary and secondary levels.[20] Nevertheless, the 1960 Constitution allows students to receive education in accordance with their religious beliefs.[21]Students from other religious backgrounds can be excused from these classes upon request by their parents and can opt for non-religious courses such as ethics or philosophy.[22] In communities with a Turkish majority, schools may be established to teach Sunni Islam, although such cases are rare.

Demographic Engineering and Violence

Forced Relocations

During the Cyprus conflict from 1963 to 1970, around 20,000 to 25,000 Turkish Cypriots were internally displaced by Greek Cypriot forces.

Following the Turkish invasion of Cyprus in 1974, between 180,000 and 200,000 Greek Cypriots were forced to flee south. Concurrently, around 50,000 to 60,000 Turkish Cypriots fled north, including many who had been displaced before.[23] Nevertheless, since these relocations were considered voluntary, with no restrictions imposed by the Cypriot government on movement, they do not qualify as instances of forced relocation. Despite the entitlement of Turkish Cypriots to citizenship in the Republic of Cyprus, most were denied access to its authorities and prohibited from crossing over to the opposite side by the occupying regime. Until April 2003, regular interactions between Greek Cypriots and Turkish Cypriots were limited, with Greek Cypriots unable to access occupied territories and Turkish Cypriots restricted by the northern regime from entering areas controlled by the Republic.[24]

[18] UNHCR, 2024.
[19] L'Aménagement Linguistique dans le Monde, 2024.
[20] Eurel, 2012.
[21] Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus, 1960. Article 20.
[22] The Association of Religion Data Archives, 2024.
[23] Norwegian Refugee Council, 2005, 28.
[24] Trimikliniotis, 2015, 5.

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Constitutions and Laws

The 1960 Constitution, established following independence from British colonial rule, defines the state as an independent republic with a presidential regime, where the President is Greek and the Vice President is Turkish, each elected by their respective communities. The Constitution recognizes two primary communities: the Greek Community, comprising citizens of Greek origin, Greek language speakers, or Greek Orthodox Christians, and the Turkish Community, comprising citizens of Turkish origin, Turkish language speakers, or Muslims. Citizens who do not fit into these categories must choose to align with either the Greek or Turkish Community, and if they belong to a religious group, they must choose as a group. The Constitution has been in force for 64 years and has been amended 18 times without altering linguistic or religious provisions.[25]

Citizenship Laws

As per the amendment introduced by Law 58/1996, individuals applying for naturalization in Cyprus must meet certain criteria. Applicants must have resided in Cyprus for seven years prior to application, be of good character, and have an intention to reside in the country.[26] The Citizenship Law of 1967 outlined a shorter term for individuals of Cypriot descent from ex-colonizing or colonized countries, with a residency requirement of 12 months or a shorter period depending on the circumstances.[27] The current law also specifies a shorter, five-year residency requirement for aliens who are parents or children of Cypriot citizens.[28]

Law 65/1999 stipulates that children born to parents who unlawfully entered or reside in Cyprus do not automatically gain citizenship.[29] This amendment appears to target Turkish nationals who settled in the northern part of the country under Turkish occupation from 1974 onwards. Greek Cypriot policymakers enacted this amendment, deeming it politically necessary to address what they perceived as an illegal settlement and colonization policy by the Turkish state.[30]

[25] Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus, 1960.
[26] Law 58/ 1996.
[27] Law 43/ 1967.
[28] Prabhu Balakrishnan, 2021.
[29] Law 65/ 1999.
[30] Trimikliniotis, 2015, 17.

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National Anthem(s)

Following Cypriot independence in 1960, national symbols such as the flag were enshrined into the new constitution, but the adoption of a national anthem was much more controversial. As the Greek and Turkish Cypriot communities could not agree on an anthem, between 1960 and 1966, different instrumental marches were used at official events and state visits. In 1966, the Greek members of the government unilaterally decided to use the Greek national anthem "Ode to Freedom" in Cyprus. However, the Turkish community does not recognize this anthem, choosing instead to use the Turkish national anthem within the Northern Turkish-controlled region of Cyprus.

In 2004, as part of the accession process to the European Union, a peace plan was put forward by the UN Secretary General to foster inclusivity by introducing various national symbols representing both Cypriot communities. This plan included a wordless anthem that received approval from both Turkish and Greek members of the national symbols committee. Despite this effort, the plan was rejected by referendum, and the Greek "Ode to Freedom" remains the Cypriot national anthem.[31] The anthem exalts the bravery of ancient Greeks and calls for the celebration of liberty, emphasizing the enduring spirit of the Greek people.

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[31] Nation Anthems.info, 2024.

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